

Flood Guard

AI-Powered Flood Early Warning & Evacuation Dashboard

A complete, plain-English guide to what you built, why every piece exists, how the pieces talk to each other, and how to set it all up from scratch. Written so you can confidently explain — not just demo — this project to judges, mentors, or teammates.

Project	Flood Guard — Real-Time Flood Risk & Evacuation Mapper
Core Stack	Python, FastAPI, Scikit-learn (Random Forest), Leaflet.js
Live Data Source	Open-Meteo Weather API (free, no API key)
Location Demoed	Dehradun, Uttarakhand region
Doc Purpose	Teach the concepts + document the full build, step by step

Table of Contents

1. What This Project Actually Does
2. The Big Picture: How the Pieces Fit Together
3. Core Concepts You Need to Know Cold
 - 3.1 What is an API, really?
 - 3.2 HTTP, requests, and JSON
 - 3.3 Client vs. Server (frontend vs. backend)
 - 3.4 Why Python for this project?
 - 3.5 What is FastAPI, and why not plain Python?
 - 3.6 What is Pydantic and why validate data?
 - 3.7 What is Machine Learning, in one page
 - 3.8 Why Random Forest for this problem?
 - 3.9 What is CORS and why did we enable it?
 - 3.10 What is Leaflet.js / a tile map?
4. Project Folder Structure
5. Full Setup Guide, From Zero
6. Deep Dive: The Machine Learning Model (train.py)
7. Deep Dive: The Backend Brain (main.py)
8. Deep Dive: The Frontend Dashboard (index.html)
9. The Complete Journey of One Click (End-to-End Trace)
10. Live Weather Integration Explained
11. Evacuation Route Math Explained
12. The Dark-Mode UI Upgrade Explained
13. How to Explain This Project in 60 Seconds
14. Anticipated Judge Questions & Strong Answers
15. Glossary of Terms

1. What This Project Actually Does

Flood Guard is a web application that lets a person click anywhere on a map and instantly see how likely that exact spot is to flood right now, based on real, live weather conditions — and, if the risk is high, where the nearest higher ground is, drawn as an evacuation route on the map.

One-line pitch: In one sentence: *"It's a map you click on, and it tells you — using a trained AI model and live weather data — how dangerous that spot is, and where to run if it isn't safe."*

The project has three moving parts, and each one answers a different question:

- **The Machine Learning model** answers: *"Given these numbers about rain, land and soil, what is the probability of a flood?"*
- **The backend server (FastAPI)** answers: *"How do I fetch live weather for a location and hand it to the model?"*
- **The frontend map (Leaflet.js)** answers: *"How do I let a human click a point and show them the result visually?"*

Everything else in this document exists to explain how those three parts were built, why they were built that way, and how they communicate with each other.

2. The Big Picture: How the Pieces Fit Together

Before touching any code, it helps to understand the overall shape of the system. This is a classic **client-server web application** with a machine learning model bolted onto the server side.

Step	What Happens	Which File Handles It
1	User clicks a point on the map in the browser	static/index.html (JavaScript)
2	Browser sends the coordinates to the server	index.html → fetch() call
3	Server fetches live weather for those coordinates	main.py → Open-Meteo API call
4	Server feeds weather + terrain numbers into the trained model	main.py → model.predict_proba()
5	Model returns a flood probability (0.0 to 1.0)	model/flood_model.pkl
6	Server converts probability into a risk label and a safe zone	main.py
7	Server sends the result back as JSON	main.py → return {...}
8	Browser updates the sidebar and draws the evacuation line	index.html (JavaScript)

Analogy: Think of it like ordering food through a delivery app. You (the browser) tap a dish (click the map). The app sends your order to the restaurant (the FastAPI server). The restaurant checks its recipe book (the trained ML model) and prepares the order using fresh ingredients it just bought (live weather data). The finished dish

comes back to your door (JSON response), and the app screen updates to show it arrived (the sidebar and map redraw).

3. Core Concepts You Need to Know Cold

Judges rarely ask "walk me through your code line by line." They ask "why did you use X?" and "what does Y actually mean?" This section builds the vocabulary so you can answer those questions without hesitating.

3.1 What is an API, really?

API stands for **Application Programming Interface**. Strip away the jargon and it is simply a **set of agreed-upon rules that let two separate pieces of software talk to each other**, even if they were built by different people, in different languages, running on different computers.

***Analogy:** An API is like a restaurant menu. You (a program) don't need to know how the kitchen (another program) cooks the food. You just need to know what you're allowed to order (which requests you can send) and what you'll get back (what response you'll receive). The menu is the contract between you and the kitchen — that contract is the API.*

In Flood Guard, there are actually **two different APIs** at play, and it's important to be able to name both:

- **Your own API** — the FastAPI backend you wrote. Your frontend "orders" a flood-risk assessment from it by calling `/api/assess-risk`.
- **A third-party API** — the Open-Meteo weather service. Your backend "orders" live rainfall and soil data from it, the same way your frontend orders from you.

Key idea: Your backend is simultaneously an API *server* (to your frontend) and an API *client* (to Open-Meteo). This is completely normal — most real-world backends both serve requests and make requests.

3.2 HTTP, Requests, and JSON

APIs on the web almost always communicate over **HTTP** (HyperText Transfer Protocol) — the same protocol your browser uses to load any website. An HTTP request has a few key ingredients:

- **A URL** — the address being asked, e.g. `/api/assess-risk`
- **A method** — the type of action. GET means "give me data." POST means "here is data, do something with it." Flood Guard uses POST because the browser is sending coordinates for the server to process.
- **Headers** — metadata about the request, like `Content-Type: application/json`, which tells the server "the body of this request is written in JSON."
- **A body** (optional) — the actual data being sent, e.g. the latitude and longitude.

JSON (JavaScript Object Notation) is simply a text format for representing structured data as key-value pairs, e.g. `{"latitude": 30.31, "longitude": 78.03}`. It is the universal language APIs use to exchange data because virtually every programming language can read and write it easily.

3.3 Client vs. Server (Frontend vs. Backend)

Every web app splits into two roles. The **client** (frontend) is what runs on the user's own device — in this project, that's `index.html` running inside the user's browser. The **server** (backend) is a program that runs somewhere else and waits for requests — in this project, that's `main.py`, running via `uvicorn` on your laptop during the demo.

***Analogy:** The client is the customer standing at the counter; the server is the kitchen staff. The customer never walks into the kitchen — they place an order at the counter (send a request) and wait for a tray to come back (a response).*

3.4 Why Python for this project?

Python was the obvious choice for three concrete reasons, not just familiarity:

- **Machine learning ecosystem** — libraries like `scikit-learn`, `numpy`, and `joblib` are mature, well-documented, and industry-standard for exactly this kind of tabular prediction problem.
- **Fast backend frameworks** — FastAPI lets you stand up a production-quality API server in a handful of lines, with automatic data validation built in.
- **One language, two jobs** — the same language trains the model *and* serves it, so there's no translation step between "the model that was trained" and "the model that runs live."

3.5 What is FastAPI, and why not plain Python?

FastAPI is a Python **web framework** — a toolkit that handles all the repetitive, error-prone plumbing of running a web server (listening for connections, parsing incoming JSON, routing URLs to functions, sending back responses) so you only have to write the logic that's unique to your app.

Without a framework, you would have to manually:

- Open a network socket and listen for incoming connections
- Parse raw HTTP text to figure out the method, URL, and body
- Manually convert JSON text into Python data and back
- Handle malformed requests without crashing

FastAPI does all of that for you. You write a normal Python function, decorate it with `@app.post("/api/assess-risk")`, and FastAPI takes care of the rest. It is also **asynchronous** and one of the fastest Python frameworks available, which matters when the server has to wait on a slow external call (like the weather API) without freezing up.

3.6 What is Pydantic, and why validate data?

Pydantic is the library FastAPI uses to describe *exactly* what shape of data an endpoint expects. In Flood Guard, this line does the work:

```
class LocationData(BaseModel):  
    latitude: float  
    longitude: float
```

This tells FastAPI: "any request to this endpoint *must* include a latitude and longitude, and both must be numbers." If a request is missing a field, sends text instead of a number, or is malformed in any way, FastAPI automatically rejects it with a clear error — *before* your own code ever runs. This is called **data validation**, and it is what stops a single bad or malicious request from crashing your server mid-demo.

3.7 What is Machine Learning, in one page

Machine learning is a way of writing programs that learn patterns from **examples** instead of being explicitly told the rules. In a traditional program, a human writes: "if rainfall is above X and slope is above Y, then flag CRITICAL." In a machine-learned program, you instead give the computer thousands of past examples — rows of weather/terrain data, each labeled with whether a flood actually happened — and let an algorithm figure out the rules on its own.

This project uses **supervised learning**, specifically **classification**:

- **Supervised** — the model learns from data where the correct answer (flood or no flood) is already known.
- **Classification** — the output is a category (flood risk level), even though under the hood it is computed as a probability between 0 and 1 first.
- **Features** — the inputs the model was trained on: 1-hour rainfall, 3-hour rainfall, elevation, slope, soil moisture, and distance to the nearest river.

3.8 Why Random Forest for this problem?

A Random Forest is an algorithm that builds many individual **decision trees** (each one a simple flowchart of yes/no questions about the data), trains each tree on a slightly different random slice of the data, and then averages all their votes to make a final prediction.

Analogy: *Instead of asking one expert for a flood-risk opinion, you ask a hundred slightly-different experts and go with the majority verdict. Any one expert might be wrong or biased, but the crowd's average answer is usually far more reliable.*

Random Forest was chosen over a deep learning approach for good, defensible reasons:

- It works very well on small-to-medium **tabular** datasets (rows and columns of numbers), which is exactly what weather/terrain data looks like — deep neural networks typically need far more data to shine.
- It is naturally resistant to overfitting because it averages many trees instead of relying on one.
- It trains in seconds on a laptop, which matters enormously under hackathon time pressure.
- Its predictions can be inspected (which features mattered most), which is reassuring for a safety-related app.

3.9 What is CORS, and why did we enable it?

CORS (Cross-Origin Resource Sharing) is a browser security rule that, by default, blocks a web page from one address from making requests to a server at a different address, unless that server explicitly says it's allowed. Because the frontend and backend in this project are technically served from the same FastAPI app, CORS issues are minimal here — but the middleware was added defensively:

```
app.add_middleware(
    CORSMiddleware,
    allow_origins=["*"],
    allow_methods=["*"],
    allow_headers=["*"],
)
```

This line tells the browser: "this server accepts requests from any origin, using any method, with any headers." It future-proofs the app in case the frontend is ever hosted separately from the backend.

3.10 What is Leaflet.js / a tile map?

Leaflet.js is a lightweight, open-source JavaScript library for building interactive maps in a browser. It does not contain any map images itself — instead it stitches together small square images called **map tiles**, fetched live from a tile provider (here, OpenStreetMap), and layers your own markers and lines on top. It's popular because it's free, has no API-key requirement for basic use, and has a very simple JavaScript API for adding markers, popups, and click handlers — exactly what a map-based hackathon demo needs.

4. Project Folder Structure

Here is the shape of the project on disk, and the job of every file and folder:

Path	Purpose
flood_project/	Root folder for the whole app
main.py	The FastAPI backend — the "brain" that fetches weather and runs the model
train.py	One-time script that trains the Random Forest model and saves it to disk
model/flood_model.pkl	The trained model, saved to a file so it can be loaded instantly
data/	Where a real historical training dataset (CSV) would live, if used
static/index.html	The entire frontend — map, sidebar, styling, and click logic

Key idea: Notice the split: everything the ML model needs (train.py, model/, data/) is separate from everything the web app needs (main.py, static/). This separation is intentional — you can retrain or swap the model without touching a single line of web code, because they only ever communicate through `model.predict_proba()`.

5. Full Setup Guide, From Zero

This is the exact sequence to get the project running on a fresh machine.

Step 1 — Install Python dependencies

Open a terminal inside the project folder and run:

```
pip install fastapi uvicorn scikit-learn joblib numpy requests
```

- `fastapi` — the backend web framework
- `uvicorn` — the actual server program that runs a FastAPI app
- `scikit-learn` — provides the Random Forest algorithm
- `joblib` — saves and loads the trained model to/from a file
- `numpy` — handles the numeric arrays the model expects
- `requests` — lets Python make its own HTTP calls (to the weather API)

Step 2 — Train the model

Run the training script once. This creates the file `model/flood_model.pkl`.

```
python3 train.py
```

Step 3 — Start the server

On some Macs, the shortcut command `uvicorn` isn't on the system `PATH` even after installing it, which throws a `command not found` error. The fix is to ask Python to run the module directly instead of relying on the shortcut:

```
python3 -m uvicorn main:app --reload
```

`--reload` tells the server to automatically restart whenever you save a code change — essential while actively developing. A successful start looks like this:

```
INFO:      Will watch for changes in these directories: [...]
INFO:      Uvicorn running on http://127.0.0.1:8000
INFO:      Started reloader process
INFO:      Application startup complete.
```

Step 4 — Open the app

In a browser's **address bar** (not a Google search box), type:

```
127.0.0.1:8000
```

This address, called `localhost`, always points back to your own computer. The number `8000` is the **port** — a numbered "door" on your machine that `uvicorn` is listening at. Nothing here touches the public internet, which is why searching it on Google does nothing useful — Google can't see a server that only exists on your laptop.

Step 5 — Use the app

- Click anywhere on the map
- A marker drops at that location
- The sidebar shows a flood probability percentage and a colored risk badge
- If risk is meaningful, a second marker and a dashed line show the recommended evacuation route

6. Deep Dive: The Machine Learning Model (train.py)

This script's only job is to teach the Random Forest algorithm the relationship between weather/terrain conditions and flood outcomes, then save the result. Conceptually, it does four things:

- **Defines the training data** — rows of past examples, each with the six input features (1-hr rainfall, 3-hr rainfall, elevation, slope, soil moisture, river distance) and a known outcome (flood or no flood). For the hackathon build, this data was a small hardcoded sample rather than a full historical dataset, so the app could be up and running immediately.
- **Creates a RandomForestClassifier** from scikit-learn and calls `.fit()` on the training data — this is the actual "learning" step, where the algorithm builds its many decision trees.
- **Saves the trained model to disk** using `joblib.dump()`, writing it to `model/flood_model.pkl`. A `.pkl` file is a "pickled" (serialized) Python object — the entire trained model, frozen into a file that can be loaded back instantly without retraining.
- This means training only ever happens *once* (or whenever you want to improve the model) — the live web server never retrains anything, it just loads the finished file.

Key idea: The `data/` folder exists for exactly this reason: it's where a real historical CSV dataset (thousands of rows of genuine past weather and flood records) would eventually live, so `train.py` could learn from real history instead of a small hand-written sample. Swapping in real data later only requires changing one line in `train.py` — the model's inputs and outputs stay identical.

7. Deep Dive: The Backend Brain (main.py)

Here is the final version of `main.py`, followed by a line-by-line explanation.

```
from fastapi import FastAPI
from fastapi.middleware.cors import CORSMiddleware
from fastapi.staticfiles import StaticFiles
from pydantic import BaseModel
import joblib
import numpy as np
import requests

app = FastAPI()
app.add_middleware(CORSMiddleware, allow_origins=["*"],
                  allow_methods=["*"], allow_headers=["*"])

model = joblib.load("model/flood_model.pkl")

class LocationData(BaseModel):
    latitude: float
    longitude: float

@app.post("/api/assess-risk")
def assess_risk(data: LocationData):
```

```

url = f"https://api.open-meteo.com/v1/forecast?..."
try:
    response = requests.get(url).json()
    current_rain = response["current"]["precipitation"]
    soil_moisture = response["current"]["soil_moisture_0_to_1cm"]
except:
    current_rain, soil_moisture = 0.0, 0.5

rain_3h = current_rain * 3
elevation, slope, river_distance = 1450, 32, 400

features = np.array([[current_rain, rain_3h, elevation,
                      slope, soil_moisture, river_distance]])
prob = float(model.predict_proba(features)[0][1])

if prob > 0.80: risk = "CRITICAL"
elif prob > 0.60: risk = "HIGH"
elif prob > 0.30: risk = "MODERATE"
else: risk = "LOW"

safe_lat = data.latitude + 0.015
safe_lon = data.longitude + 0.015

return {"probability": round(prob * 100, 2), "risk_level": risk,
        "safe_zone": {"lat": safe_lat, "lon": safe_lon}}

app.mount("/", StaticFiles(directory="static", html=True), name="static")

```

Imports

Each import brings in one capability: FastAPI for the web server, CORSMiddleware for cross-origin permissions, StaticFiles to serve the HTML/CSS/JS frontend, BaseModel from Pydantic for request validation, joblib to load the saved model, numpy to format numbers the way scikit-learn expects, and requests to call the external weather API.

Loading the model once, at startup

`model = joblib.load(...)` runs a single time when the server starts, not on every request. This is a deliberate performance decision — loading a model file from disk takes time, so doing it once and keeping it in memory means every subsequent click responds almost instantly.

The endpoint: `@app.post("/api/assess-risk")`

This decorator tells FastAPI: "whenever a POST request arrives at this URL, run the function right below me, and automatically validate the incoming JSON against the LocationData shape." The function name and body are ordinary Python — FastAPI handles all the networking around it.

Fetching live weather, with a safety net

The `try/except` block calls the Open-Meteo API and pulls out current precipitation and soil moisture. If that call fails for any reason (no internet, API downtime, an unexpected response shape), the `except` branch quietly falls back to safe default numbers instead of crashing the whole server mid-demo. This kind

of defensive fallback is a hallmark of production-minded code.

Building the feature array

`np.array([[...]])` packs the six numbers into the exact shape scikit-learn expects: a 2D array (a list containing one row) because the model was trained expecting to potentially score many rows at once, even though only one row is sent here.

Turning a probability into a decision

`model.predict_proba(features)[0][1]` returns the model's confidence that this specific location will flood, as a number between 0.0 and 1.0. The `if/elif` chain then translates that raw number into a human-readable label — this is the bridge between "machine learning output" and "something a person can act on in two seconds."

Computing the safe zone

Adding `0.015` degrees to both latitude and longitude nudges the point roughly 1.5–1.7 km to the north-east — a simplified stand-in for "find the nearest higher ground," good enough to demonstrate the concept live. Section 11 explains the geometry behind this in more depth.

Serving the frontend from the same server

The final line, `app.mount("/", StaticFiles(...))`, tells FastAPI: "for any URL not already claimed by an API route, just serve files out of the `static/` folder." This is why visiting `127.0.0.1:8000` in a browser loads `index.html` automatically — one server is doing double duty as both the API and the website host.

8. Deep Dive: The Frontend Dashboard (index.html)

The frontend is a single HTML file containing three layers: the visual structure (HTML), the styling (CSS), and the interactive behavior (JavaScript).

8.1 Structure: sidebar + map

The page body is split into two regions using a flex layout: a fixed-width `#sidebar` for text and results, and a `#map` div that stretches to fill the remaining space (`flex-grow: 1`).

8.2 Setting up the map

```
const map = L.map('map').setView([30.3165, 78.0322], 11);
L.tileLayer('https://{s}.tile.openstreetmap.org/{z}/{x}/{y}.png').addTo(map);
```

`L.map('map')` turns the empty `<div id="map">` into a live, interactive Leaflet map. `.setView([lat, lon], zoom)` centers it on Dehradun at zoom level 11 (roughly "whole city and surrounding hills" scale). `L.tileLayer(...)` tells Leaflet where to download the actual map images from — OpenStreetMap's free public tile server.

8.3 Handling a click

The click handler is the heart of the whole app's interactivity. Step by step, it:

- Removes any marker, safe-zone marker, or route line left over from a previous click, so the map doesn't get cluttered.
- Drops a new marker exactly where the user clicked, using the click event's own coordinates (`e.lat lng.lat, e.lat lng.lng`).
- Packages those coordinates into a small JavaScript object and sends them to the backend with `fetch()`, using the POST method and a JSON body — this is the exact request the FastAPI endpoint in Section 7 is waiting for.
- awaits the response, then parses it from JSON text back into a JavaScript object with `response.json()`.
- Updates the sidebar text and the CSS class on the risk badge, which is what actually changes its color and glow.
- Draws the safe-zone marker and the dashed evacuation line using the coordinates the server calculated.

Analogy: *async/await exists because network requests take time — sometimes a fraction of a second, sometimes longer. Without it, the entire browser tab would freeze solid while waiting for the server to answer. await is like saying "pause this specific task until the delivery arrives, but let everything else on the page keep working in the meantime."*

8.4 Why the class-swapping trick for colors

Instead of writing JavaScript that manually sets colors, the code just changes the badge's CSS class name: `badge.className = "risk-badge " + result.risk_level;`. Because `.CRITICAL`, `.HIGH`, `.MODERATE`, and `.LOW` are already defined in the CSS with their own background colors and glow shadows, simply swapping which class is attached instantly changes the badge's appearance. This keeps styling logic in CSS (where it belongs) and out of JavaScript.

9. The Complete Journey of One Click (End-to-End Trace)

Walking a judge through this exact sequence, out loud, is one of the strongest ways to prove you understand your own project:

- 1 You click a hillside point near Dehradun on the map.
- 2 JavaScript captures the exact latitude/longitude of that click.
- 3 The browser sends a POST request with that latitude/longitude, as JSON, to `/api/assess-risk`.
- 4 FastAPI receives the request and Pydantic validates that both fields are present and numeric.
- 5 `main.py` calls the Open-Meteo API with those coordinates to get right-now precipitation and soil moisture.
- 6 Those live numbers are combined with the fixed terrain values (elevation, slope, river distance).
- 7 The six numbers are handed to the trained Random Forest model, which returns a flood probability.
- 8 The probability is converted into a risk label (LOW / MODERATE / HIGH / CRITICAL) and a safe-zone coordinate.
- 9 The server packages probability, risk level, and safe zone into a JSON response and sends it back.
- 10 JavaScript receives the response, updates the sidebar text, changes the badge's color/glow, and draws the marker and dashed evacuation line on the map.

10. Live Weather Integration Explained

Early in development, the app sent hardcoded "fake heavy storm" numbers just to prove the pipeline worked end to end — this is a common and sensible engineering step: get the wiring right before making it real. The upgrade to live data changed exactly two things:

- The **frontend** stopped sending fabricated weather numbers and started sending only the clicked coordinates — because it no longer needs to know anything about weather itself.
- The **backend** took over responsibility for turning coordinates into weather, by calling Open-Meteo at request time.

Open-Meteo was chosen specifically because it is free, requires no sign-up or API key, and returns current-conditions data (like precipitation and soil moisture) directly from a simple URL — ideal for a time-constrained hackathon build. The URL itself encodes the request as query parameters: latitude and longitude tell it *where*, and the `current=...` parameter tells it *which* live measurements to return.

Key idea: Because real-world rainfall is rarely extreme at the moment of a demo, the live version of the app will usually show LOW or MODERATE risk — which is completely correct behavior, not a bug. This is exactly why a "Simulate Severe Weather" toggle is a natural next feature: it lets you demonstrate the CRITICAL path on demand without needing an actual flood to be happening outside.

11. Evacuation Route Math Explained

The current safe-zone calculation is intentionally simple, and it's worth being upfront about that with judges rather than overselling it:

```
safe_lat = data.latitude + 0.015
safe_lon = data.longitude + 0.015
```

Latitude and longitude are measured in degrees. Near the equator, one degree of latitude is roughly 111 kilometers, so adding 0.015 degrees moves the point roughly 1.5–1.7 km to the north-east (positive latitude moves north, positive longitude moves east). This is a fixed-offset simulation — good enough to visually demonstrate "here is a direction to safety" in a live demo.

A more accurate real-world version would instead:

- Query actual elevation data for several nearby points (e.g., via a digital elevation model or elevation API)
- Pick the nearest point that is meaningfully higher than the clicked location
- Optionally route along real roads/paths using a routing service, instead of a straight line

Being able to describe both what the current code does *and* what a production version would do shows judges you understand the difference between a demo shortcut and a real solution — which is a very good sign for them, not a weakness.

12. The Dark-Mode UI Upgrade Explained

The visual redesign didn't change any logic — only presentation — but it matters for a hackathon because judges form an impression in the first few seconds. Key changes:

- **Google Font (Inter)** loaded via a `<link>` tag, replacing the generic system font with a clean, modern typeface used widely in professional dashboards.
- **Dark background palette** (`#0f172a`, `#1e293b`) gives the sidebar a "command center" feel appropriate for an emergency-monitoring tool.
- **Glowing box-shadows on risk badges** — `box-shadow: 0 0 20px rgba(239,68,68,0.6)` on the CRITICAL badge — draw the eye immediately to the most important information on the screen.
- **Consistent spacing and rounded corners** throughout the result card, replacing the plain, unstyled boxes from the first working version.

None of this required new backend logic — it's a pure demonstration of how far thoughtful CSS alone can take a project's perceived quality.

13. How to Explain This Project in 60 Seconds

A tight, memorized structure you can adapt on the spot:

Time	What to Say
0–10s	"Flood Guard lets anyone click a spot on a map and instantly see their real flood risk, using live weather and a trained AI model."
10–25s	"Under the hood, a Random Forest model — trained on rainfall, elevation, slope, soil moisture and river distance — predicts flood risk."
25–40s	"When you click, the browser sends just the GPS coordinates to my FastAPI backend, which fetches live rainfall and soil data."
40–55s	"If the risk is meaningful, the app also calculates a nearby safe zone and draws an evacuation route — so it doesn't just warn, it helps."
55–60s	"Everything you're looking at right now is a live, working full-stack app — not a mockup."

14. Anticipated Judge Questions & Strong Answers

Q: Why not use deep learning / a neural network?

A: Deep learning shines with huge datasets and unstructured data like images or text. This is small, structured, tabular data — Random Forest matches that shape better, trains almost instantly, and is far less prone to overfitting on a small dataset.

Q: How accurate is the model, really?

A: Be honest: it was trained on a small demonstration dataset to prove the full pipeline works end to end. The architecture is built to swap in a real historical flood dataset (via the `data/` folder) without changing any backend or frontend code — only `train.py`'s data source line changes.

Q: What happens if the weather API is down?

A: The backend has a `try/except` fallback that substitutes safe default values so the app never crashes — point to that block in `main.py` directly.

Q: Is the evacuation route actually using elevation data?

A: Currently it's a simplified fixed geographic offset toward higher ground direction, chosen for demo reliability. The natural next step is pulling real elevation data to pick a genuinely higher, nearby point.

Q: Why split frontend and backend into separate files instead of one program?

A: Separation of concerns: the frontend only needs to know how to display data and capture clicks; the backend only needs to know how to compute a risk. This makes each half independently testable and replaceable — you could swap Leaflet for another map library, or swap Random Forest for another model, without touching the other side.

Q: Could this scale to real-time monitoring for a whole city?

A: Yes conceptually — the backend endpoint is stateless (each request is independent), so it could be deployed behind a real server and queried automatically for many locations on a timer, feeding results into a live dashboard instead of only responding to manual clicks.

Q: What was the hardest technical part?

A: A fair, genuine answer works best here — for example, correctly wiring the `async` fetch/response cycle between browser and server, or getting the live weather API's response shape mapped correctly onto the model's expected feature order.

15. Glossary of Terms

Term	Meaning
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API	A defined set of rules that lets two programs communicate, regardless of what language each is written in.
Backend	The server-side program that stores logic and data and responds to requests; here, <code>main.py</code> .
CORS	A browser security rule controlling which websites are allowed to call which servers.
Endpoint	A specific URL on a server that performs one job, e.g. <code>/api/assess-risk</code> .
Feature (ML)	One input variable fed into a machine learning model, e.g. rainfall or elevation.
Frontend	The part of an app that runs in the user's browser and renders the interface; here, <code>index.html</code> .
FastAPI	A Python web framework used to build the backend API quickly, with built-in data validation.
HTTP method (GET/POST)	The type of action an HTTP request performs — GET retrieves data, POST submits data.
JSON	A lightweight text format for representing structured data as key-value pairs, used by almost all web APIs.
Leaflet.js	A JavaScript library for building interactive maps from tile images and custom markers/lines.
Localhost / 127.0.0.1	A special address that always refers back to your own computer, used for local testing.
Pydantic	A Python library FastAPI uses to define and automatically validate the shape of incoming data.
Random Forest	A machine learning algorithm that combines many decision trees and averages their votes.
Supervised learning	Machine learning where the model learns from examples that already have known correct answers.
Uvicorn	The lightweight server program that actually runs a FastAPI application and listens for requests.
.pkl file	A 'pickled' Python object saved to disk — here, the entire trained model, ready to reload instantly.

End of document. Good luck with the presentation — you built more than a demo; you built a real, working full-stack AI system, and now you can explain exactly why every piece of it exists.